

SIDE BEND

Pariivrtta Janu Sirsasana

This seated, lateral side stretch allows you to mobilize your spine in a way that you probably don't often move it in everyday life. The novel movement that this pose involves benefits your intervertebral discs, nervous system, and fascia.

THE BIG PICTURE

As you bend deeply to the side, muscles along your spine stretch and strengthen. Your shoulder muscles engage to reach your arms over your head, and your thigh muscles on both sides stretch in different ways.

Neck

To rotate your neck, your **rotatores**, **multifidus**, **sternocleidomastoid**, and **semispinalis cervicis** engage on the side toward the ground (model's right in this image), while stretching on the upward-facing side. Your **splenius capitis** and **splenius cervicis** engage on the upward-facing side (model's left in this image), while stretching on the downward-facing side.

Sternocleidomastoid

Brachioradialis
Serratus anterior

Shoulder

Deltoids
Triceps brachii
Biceps brachii
Brachialis
Elbow

Arms

Your **shoulder flexors**—including the **anterior deltoids**—engage. Your **middle deltoids** and **supraspinatus** engage to abduct your shoulders, and they are externally rotated by your **posterior deltoids**, **infraspinatus**, and **teres minor** muscles. Your **brachialis**, **biceps**, and **brachioradialis** muscles flex your elbows.

KEY

•-- Joints

○ Muscles

● Engaging

● Engaging while stretching

● Stretching

Extended lower leg

Your **ankle dorsiflexors** engage to dorsiflex your ankle and extend your toes. If you are grabbing your foot and pulling, you are probably feeling a stretch in your **calf muscles**, along with your **plantar muscles** and **fascia**.

Gastrocnemius
Flexor d. longus
Tibialis anterior
Ankle
Plantar fascia

Thigh

Your **hamstrings** and **gluteus maximus** stretch, while your **quadriceps** engage to extend your knee. Also, your **internal rotators**—including **gluteus medius**, **gluteus minimus**, and **tensor fasciae latae**—engage while lengthening. You may feel a stretch in your **iliotibial band**.